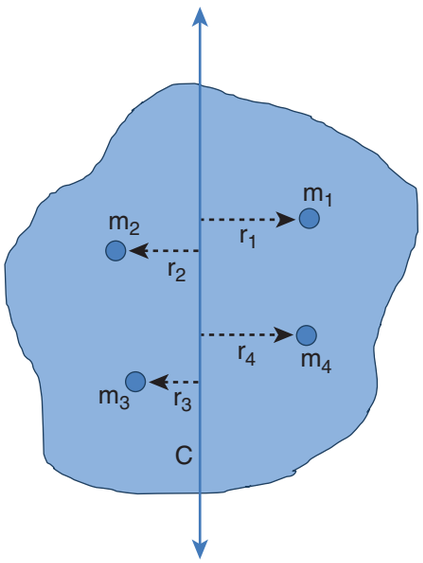


Figure 5.24 Radius of gyration

$$m = m_1 = m_2 = m_3 = \ldots = m_n$$

then,

$$I = mr_1^2 + mr_2^2 + mr_3^2 + \cdots + mr_n^2$$

$$= m\left(r_1^2 + r_2^2 + r_3^2 + \cdots + r_n^2\right)$$

$$= nm\left(\frac{r_1^2 + r_2^2 + r_3^2 + \cdots + r_n^2}{n}\right)$$

$$I = MK^2$$

where, nm is the total mass M of the body and K is the radius of gyration.

$$K = \sqrt{\frac{r_1^2 + r_2^2 + r_3^2 + \cdots + r_n^2}{n}} \qquad (5.45)$$

The expression for radius of gyration indicates that it is the root mean square (rms) distance of the particles of the body from the axis of rotation.

In fact, the moment of inertia of any object could be expressed in the form, $I = MK^2$.

For example, let us take the moment of inertia of a uniform rod of mass M and length ℓ. Its moment of inertia with respect to a perpendicular axis passing through the centre of mass is, $I = \frac{1}{12}M\ell^2$

In terms of radius of gyration, $I = MK^2$

Hence, $MK^2 = \frac{1}{12}M\ell^2$

$$K^2 = \frac{1}{12}\ell^2$$

$$K = \frac{1}{\sqrt{12}}\ell \text{ or } K = \frac{1}{2\sqrt{3}}\ell \text{ or } K = (0.289)\ell$$

EXAMPLE 5.15

Find the radius of gyration of a disc of mass M and radius R rotating about an axis passing through the centre of mass and perpendicular to the plane of the disc.

Solution

The moment of inertia of a disc about an axis passing through the centre of mass and perpendicular to the disc is, $I = \frac{1}{2}MR^2$

In terms of radius of gyration, $I = MK^2$

Hence, $MK^2 = \frac{1}{2}MR^2$; $K^2 = \frac{1}{2}R^2$

$$K = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}}R \text{ or } K = \frac{1}{1.414}R \text{ or } K = (0.707)R$$

From the case of a rod and also a disc, we can conclude that the radius of gyration of the rigid body is always a geometrical feature like length, breadth, radius or their combinations with a positive numerical value multiplied to it.

UNIT-5(XI-Physics_Vol-1).indd 238 06-01-2022 17:47:21